Why did India adopt an aggressive approach at some points in time while it remained conciliatory and accommodating of pro-Pakistan groups in Afghanistan at others? What drives India's policy towards Afghanistan and what does this reflect about its rise as a power of regional and global importance?

Based on a host of primary and secondary sources (detailed in the following sections), this book analyses these questions and brings to life India's internal debates on Afghanistan and the various themes it embodies. Starting with the Soviet military invasion of Afghanistan in 1979, to the fall of the communist-turned-nationalist government of Mohammad Najibullah in 1992, to the rise of the Taliban in 1996, and the events that ensued following the 9/11 attacks until the withdrawal of NATO forces, and the failing reconciliation process under Afghan president Ashraf Ghani, the book chronicles shifts in India's Afghanistan policy, and examines the reasons for the same. It shows that there has been a consensus in New Delhi's power circles that an independent, genuinely sovereign, territorially united, and economically strong Afghanistan is in the best interests of India and the world. Nonetheless, political rivalries within Afghanistan have exposed the fissures within India's policy-making circuits regarding what India should or should not do to help build a united and stable Afghanistan. Most of these differences are essentially over matters of operational and tactical relevance. Some Indian officials advocate a non-military, mostly economic, and politically neutral approach, whereas others argue in favour of a militarily robust, economically aggressive, and, politically partisan approach.

Conciliators: For the first group of policymakers, termed 'conciliators' in this book, India should focus on whoever comes to power in Kabul without fear or favour. For this to happen, India should build goodwill among the people of Afghanistan and politically engage with almost every entity, including the Afghan Taliban and its various factions. An approach marked by political pragmatism, not engaging with pro-Pakistan Afghan factions is not a viable option according to the conciliators. Indian policymakers with such beliefs gravitate towards the 'engage-with-all' axiom, however difficult it may be to open and sustain dialogue with pro-Pakistan factions in Afghanistan.

Partisans: For the second group, termed 'partisans', the mantra of making friends in Afghanistan is different. All factions that stand at odds with Pakistan